

negotiations *before* you walk down the aisle. Contract talks are a fantastic vetting process. I've gone into a lot of boardrooms with levelheaded people, only to watch them turn into crazy people when things don't go their way. Instability is not a great trait in a business partner; it's never worse in a spouse or coparent.

Think of a prenup as a way to rationally consider the worst while you still really love your partner. You've been dating for six months, you haven't merged lives or made any outsized promises, but you are into each other; that's the time for hard conversations. And never apologize for bringing up the topic. Introduce it as a fact.

"Things are great, and I've never been happier. So it's hard to imagine this falling apart. But poo-poo happens. We both know that. And we'd be fools to think we're above the statistics. And I know I'm not marrying a fool. So let's talk money, honey. What do you expect to walk away with in the event I turn into Mr. Hyde?"

That's how I would do it. But you have to come up with your own dialogue, something that suits your style and reflects your concerns. Here are a few more things to keep in mind going forward:

Don't do it yourself. You can find all sorts of prenuptial agreement forms on the Internet with handy templates, but I don't recommend them, especially if you have assets totaling over \$250,000. This isn't a time to scrimp. A good prenup will cost anywhere between \$5,000 and \$25,000, but it'll be the best money you've spent, because it'll save you many times that amount in the event of divorce.

Lawyer up. You will both need your own representation for a prenup, someone acting only in your interests and the interests of your money. Pick your lawyer based on your own personality preference. Want a keen negotiator, or someone who has the ability to gently coax? Also, don't just hire a lawyer; take his or her advice.

Keep it simple. Prenups can cover anything and everything, so a lot of people go crazy on the details. I suggest you avoid bogging down the document with issues like who keeps the salt-and-pepper-shaker collection or the set of prized golf clubs. Stick to divvying up large assets (who gets what), bills and debt (who pays what), property (who owns what), and estate (who inherits what). As I mentioned, child support falls under a different category, and even if you don't marry,